

Chickpea Casserole with Spinach & Feta

This Chickpea Casserole is a cozy, one-pan meal that's both hearty and wholesome. Tender spinach, nutty chickpeas and brown rice are bound together with a touch of cream cheese and finished with tangy feta. Fresh dill, nutmeg and lemon juice brighten the flavors, while a hint of red pepper adds gentle heat. Baked until bubbling and topped with lemon zest, it's a dish that feels comforting yet vibrant.

By **Renu Anshie Dhar** | Published on October 28, 2025

 Reviewed by Dietitian **Emily Lachtrupp, M.S., RD**

Active Time: 30 mins

Total Time: 55 mins

Servings: 4

Nutrition Profile:

No Added Sugar Gut Healthy Anti-Inflammatory Mediterranean Diet Sesame-Free High-Calcium Bone Health Weight Loss Nut-Free Healthy Pregnancy Healthy Aging Healthy Immunity Soy-Free High-Fiber Vegetarian High-Protein Egg-Free Gluten-Free

Ingredients

- 2 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil
- ½ cup chopped yellow onion
- 3 cloves garlic, finely chopped (about 1 tablespoon)
- ½ teaspoon crushed red pepper
- 1 (16-ounce) package baby spinach
- ½ cup lower-sodium vegetable broth
- 2 (15-ounce) cans no-salt-added chickpeas, rinsed
- 2 cups precooked brown rice (from 2 8.8-ounce packages)
- 2 ounces reduced-fat cream cheese
- ¼ cup chopped fresh dill, plus more for garnish
- 1 teaspoon grated lemon zest
- 3 tablespoons lemon juice
- ⅛ teaspoon ground nutmeg
- 6 ounces feta cheese, crumbled

Directions

Step 1

Preheat oven to 400°F. Heat 2 tablespoons oil in a large oven-safe skillet over medium heat. Add ½ cup onion, the chopped garlic and ½ teaspoon crushed red pepper; cook, stirring often, until the onion softens, 2 to 3 minutes.

Step 2

Add 16 ounces baby spinach in batches; cook, stirring frequently, until wilted, about 7 minutes. Continue cooking, stirring occasionally, until the liquid reduces slightly, about 1 minute.

Step 3

Add ½ cup broth; bring to a boil over medium-high heat, scraping up browned bits from the pan. Remove from heat; stir in rinsed chickpeas, 2 cups rice, 2 ounces cream cheese, ¼ cup dill, 3 tablespoons lemon juice and ⅛ teaspoon nutmeg until combined. Sprinkle with crumbled feta and stir gently once or twice.

Step 4

Cover and bake until bubbling around the edges, 20 to 22 minutes. Let rest for 5 minutes. Sprinkle with 1 teaspoon lemon zest. Garnish with additional dill, if desired.

To make ahead

Assemble through Step 3, cover and refrigerate for up to 24 hours. Bring to room temperature and bake as directed.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I swap the canned chickpeas for dried?

Of course. Canned chickpeas will save you a lot of time, but freshly cooked chickpeas will be delicious. Since the recipe calls for 2 cans, you'll need to soak at least 3½ cups of dried chickpeas overnight. After soaking, allow about 2 hours for cooking them on the stovetop until they are tender, or about an hour in a pressure cooker.

Can I use any kind of feta?

Pre-crumbled feta often tends to be dry, so we highly recommend using feta in brine. It's easy enough to crumble by hand, and it will provide the creamiest texture.

How do I prevent a watery casserole?

Adding spinach in batches ensures it wilts evenly and quickly without overcrowding the pan. Taking an extra minute to cook off the liquid after wilting is important to prevent the casserole from becoming watery.

How should I store and reheat leftovers?



Store leftovers in an airtight container in the refrigerator for up to 4 days. Reheat gently in the microwave or oven, adding a splash of broth or water, if needed, to improve the texture.

What should I serve with Chickpea Casserole?



Our Cucumber & Tomato Salad with Preserved Lemon or Purslane, Cucumber & Tomato Salad with Mint would be a perfect pairing. If you want to add more veggies into the mix, consider grilling your favorites or trying one of our recommended recipes: Creamy Oven-Roasted Zucchini & Summer Squash, Baked Breaded Eggplant or Sheet-Pan Roasted Root Vegetables.

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Nutrition Facts

Per serving: **Serving Size 1½ cups** 568 calories; total fat 24g; saturated fat 10g; cholesterol 48mg; sodium 564mg; total carbohydrate 69g; dietary fiber 15g; total sugars 10g; added sugars 0g; protein 24g; vitamin c 38mg; calcium 431mg; iron 8mg; potassium 1218mg

Additional reporting by Sarah Pflugradt, Ph.D., RDN, CSCS and Linda Frahm

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